

TrueGrade

Estimates calibrated to your real costs.

Capabilities & Client Inputs

What we are building for heavy civil estimating, and what we need from your team to make it a natural part of every bid.

Estimating you can trust, built on your own numbers.

TrueGrade is an estimating platform for heavy civil and sitework contractors. It drafts the slowest, most error-prone parts of a bid (reading the plan set, pulling quantities, building material lists, chasing supplier prices). Your estimator then confirms every number. The result is an estimate built from **your** labor, equipment, production rates, and supplier quotes. Not industry averages.

1

Your numbers, not ours

TrueGrade ships empty by design. No built-in rates, no seeded price database, no “typical” production. Every figure in an estimate is entered, uploaded, or confirmed by your team.

2

AI assists. You verify.

AI drafts quantities, materials, and prices. Nothing reaches an estimate until an estimator confirms it, and every AI-suggested value is labeled as such until then.

3

Every number is traceable

Each quantity links to the document, sheet, and location it came from. Each price shows its source and date. Any line can explain its own math.

What your team gets

One home for your costs

Labor, equipment, materials, suppliers, and production rates, refined anytime.

A reviewed takeoff

Drafted from the owner's own bid schedule and plan tables, confirmed by you.

Supplier-ready RFQs

Numbered, branded, and grouped by supplier category, with quotes compared side by side.

Bids that match the form

Estimates organized by the owner's bid items, exported in their exact order.

Sharper every job

Actual costs feed back to calibrate future estimates, with your approval.

Who it is built for

Estimators bidding earthwork, utilities, paving, and structures (bridges) on federal, state DOT, county/city, and private work. Here, precision beats speed. If the numbers don't match reality, the tool doesn't get used, so every design decision starts with accuracy.

Fits how you already work

Every file TrueGrade generates can be downloaded. Send supplier RFQs from inside the app *or* from your own email to anyone you choose, and quotes come back into the estimate either way. Your private workspace lives at interstaterock.theanswerai.com, walled off from every other company.

One bid, start to finish.

The whole product exists to deliver one loop: from the owner’s bid package to a defensible bid, with supplier prices in between. Here is what your estimator does, and what TrueGrade does, at each step.

YOUR ESTIMATOR		TRUEGRADE
1	Set up your costs once Enter or upload labor, equipment, materials, suppliers, and production rates. Refine anytime.	Turns plain-language answers ("how many cubic yards can your crew place in a day?") into the calculations behind every estimate.
2	Upload the bid package Plan set, bid form, specifications, geotech report, addenda, and optional CAD exchange files.	Splits the plan set into an indexed, searchable set of sheets and tags each document, working in the background while your team keeps going.
3	Review the draft takeoff Confirm or correct every quantity against the plan sheet.	Extracts quantities from the bid schedule, plan tables, and (flagged for extra scrutiny) the drawings themselves.
4	Build the estimate Map bid items to your assemblies and adjust anything for this specific job.	Calculates labor, equipment, and materials from your data, showing the math and how much of the estimate is verified.
5	Generate the material list & RFQs Choose which suppliers get which packages.	Consolidates every material across bid items and builds numbered, supplier-ready RFQ spreadsheets grouped by category.
6	Send and collect prices Send from TrueGrade or from your own email. Prices come back as a filled spreadsheet, an online form, a supplier PDF, or pasted email text.	Matches every returned price to the right line, compares suppliers side by side, and flags gaps, exclusions, and expired quotes.
7	Submit, then learn Produce the bid documents. After the job, enter actual costs.	Generates the bid summary and a bid form in the owner’s exact order, then compares estimated to actual to suggest calibrations you approve.

AI drafts Quantities, materials, and prices arrive labeled as suggestions.	You review Each item shows its source, confidence, and sheet link.	Then it counts Only confirmed values flow into the estimate.
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The rule that runs through every step: nothing flows into an estimate silently.

What we are building.

Six connected modules. Your team can start with what it has and improve over time. Nothing is locked, everything autosaves, and every screen explains itself in plain language.

1 Company Setup: “Make It Yours”

Set your costs once. Refine them anytime. Always one click away in the main menu.

Company basics

Logo, accent color, markup, overhead, sales tax, project types bid, bonding and insurance approach, and your standard RFQ email.

Equipment

Ownership, operating, and standby cost per hour plus mobilization per move. Or upload an equipment cost report and review the extraction.

Production rates

Answer in plain language (“how many CY can your crew place and compact in 8 hours?”) and pick the crew. We handle the formulas.

Assemblies

Reusable work packages (say, “8-inch sewer, 8 ft deep”) tying materials, crew, equipment, and production together, with a live cost per unit.

Every step is skippable, saveable, and re-editable. A completeness score shows what is left, and estimates flag any line that relies on an unverified value.

Labor

Roles with base wage, burden %, and a separate prevailing / Davis-Bacon rate. Or upload a wage determination and review the extraction.

Materials & supplier directory

Unit cost, density, waste %, and quote-expiry warnings. Supplier and subcontractor directories by category and service area, with Excel/CSV import.

Soil & material behavior

Your own swell and shrink percentages by soil type, with a before/after volume visual.

Email sending OPTIONAL

Send RFQs from TrueGrade, your company domain, or each estimator’s own Google or Microsoft mailbox.

2 Plan Room & Takeoff: “Upload the Bid Package”

From a 500-sheet plan set to a reviewed quantity takeoff, with every number traceable.

Upload the whole package

Plan sets of hundreds of sheets and hundreds of MB, bid forms, specs, geotech, addenda, and CAD files (LandXML for earthwork; DXF/DWG stored for reference). Uploads resume if interrupted, and processing runs in the background.

Cost control on AI processing

Heavy AI analysis runs only on takeoff-relevant sheets. Before it starts you see the estimated time and cost, your Admin sets limits, and AI cost is logged.

Sheet index

Sheets are split out, title blocks read into a searchable index with thumbnails, and each sheet classified (grading, utility plan & profile, paving, structures, traffic control, and more). You can correct any of it.

Manual takeoff tools, always available

Plan viewer with per-sheet scale calibration (click two points of known distance) plus linear, polyline, area, and count tools. Click any quantity to jump to its exact spot on the sheet.

Quantities come from three sources, ranked by reliability

1 · MOST RELIABLE

The owner's bid schedule. Extracted into an editable table (item number, description, spec section, unit, quantity). The estimate is organized by these bid items, so your final bid maps 1:1 to the owner's bid form.

2 · RELIABLE

Tabulated data on the plans. Quantity summaries, pipe schedules, structure and manhole tables, curb and sidewalk tables, and earthwork summaries, each with its sheet reference.

3 · LEAST RELIABLE

AI-assisted measurement, always flagged amber. Suggested pipe run lengths, structure counts, and paved areas shown as overlays on the sheet, each with Accept / Edit / Reject.

Earthwork, handled honestly

TrueGrade does **not** guess cut and fill from PDF contours. Earthwork comes from the bid schedule, from comparing imported LandXML surfaces, or from manual entry with a source note, then applies your swell and shrink factors.

Addenda

Upload anytime for a before/after diff of changed items, quantities, and sheets, with version history and acknowledgment tracking. RFQs already sent are flagged, with a revision offered.

Mandatory review

One table lists every extracted or suggested quantity with its source, confidence, and sheet link. Each must be confirmed before it feeds the estimate. Gaps versus the owner's quantities beyond a % you set are flagged.

Specifications

Requirements referenced by bid items (gradation, binder grade, pipe class, concrete strength) are pulled with section references so RFQs state exactly what is needed. Missing standard specs are flagged.

3 Estimate Builder

Confirmed quantities become an estimate you can explain line by line.

Pre-populated from your takeoff

Organized by the owner's bid items, or by default sections (Earthwork, Wet Utilities, Paving & Concrete, Structures, Indirect Costs) when there is no bid schedule.

Job-level overrides

Change any rate, production rate, price, or equipment cost for this job without touching company defaults. Overrides are marked and logged with an optional reason.

Confidence indicator

Each line shows if it rests on calibrated data, verified values, supplier quotes, or unverified values. A summary reads, for example, "82% of this estimate is based on calibrated, verified, or quoted data."

Bid item mapping

Each bid item maps to one or more of your assemblies. AI suggests, you confirm. Unmapped items block final output, so nothing slips through unpriced.

"How was this calculated?"

On every line: the math in plain English, the values that fed it, and a link to the source sheet.

Built for real jobs

Open shop or prevailing wage, haul distances, tax, and permits. Estimates are saved, duplicable, and versioned, and keep their original values unless you recalculate.

4 Material List & Supplier RFQs: “Get Prices”

From confirmed quantities to comparable supplier quotes, however you prefer to send.

Material list

Confirmed quantities × assembly components, using your own conversions (density, thickness, swell and shrink). Identical materials are consolidated across bid items with traceability kept. Fully editable, and subcontractor scope packages work the same way.

Two first-class ways to send **YOUR CHOICE**

Send from TrueGrade: you approve every email; suppliers get the spreadsheet plus a secure no-login form; status and reminders are tracked. **Or export and send it yourself:** Excel, PDF, CSV, or .zip, with ready-to-paste email text.

Side-by-side quote comparison

Lowest complete price highlighted; missing lines, exclusions, expired quotes, off-spec alternates, and outdated revisions flagged. Selected prices flow into the estimate with supplier, date, and expiry.

Professional RFQ spreadsheets

One per supplier category plus a combined master, each with a unique number (for example **IR-2026-0142-AGG-R0**) in the file name, header, and email subject. Your logo leads, and only the supplier's cells are editable.

Four ways for prices to come back

Online form; filled Excel (auto-matched by RFQ number and line IDs); the supplier's own PDF quote; or pasted email text. The last two use AI extraction with mandatory review. Bulk upload supported.

Never lose track

Every download and send is logged. If quantities change after an RFQ goes out, a banner offers Revision 1, 2, and so on. Reminders on RFQs you sent yourself come to **you**.

5 Learn From Past Jobs & Close-Out

Your history becomes the calibration that makes the next estimate sharper.

Teach TrueGrade from completed jobs

Upload past estimates and job cost reports (PDF, Excel/CSV, even photos of printed reports). AI extracts the lines; you review them beside the source and map them to your setup. Nothing is auto-imported. Manual entry is available too.

Close out this job

Enter or upload final actual costs against the saved estimate and feed the same review and calibration, so learning becomes a habit, not a project.

Variance calibration

Estimated versus actual per activity, with suggested adjustments. Each needs your Approve, Edit, or Dismiss. Nothing adjusts on its own.

6 Bid Output

Branded documents your team can hand off, and a bid form that matches the owner's.

Bid summary PDF

Line items, subtotals, markup, and total in your branding (“Powered by TrueGrade” small in the footer). Choose a **client version** that hides internal cost detail, or an **internal version**.

Full estimate export

The complete estimate in Excel, plus RFQ and quote-comparison exports.

Bid form export

Unit prices and extensions in the exact item order of the owner's bid schedule, as Excel and PDF, ready to transfer to the official form.

Yours to download

Every file the app generates is downloadable. You are never forced to send, share, or finish anything inside TrueGrade.

Built so your estimators will rely on it.

Estimating tools fail when people stop trusting the numbers. Every design decision below keeps your estimator in control and able to explain any figure to a bonding company, an owner, or a boss.

Will it make up numbers?	No rates or prices come pre-loaded. Every value is entered, uploaded, or confirmed by your company, and estimates flag exactly which lines rely on unverified values, even if setup isn't finished.
What if the AI misreads a sheet?	AI output is always a draft. Each quantity shows its source, its confidence (amber means low), and a link to the exact spot on the sheet. Nothing feeds the estimate until a person confirms it.
Can we audit any number?	Every line has a "How was this calculated?" view in plain English, every price shows its source and date, and bids export in the owner's exact bid-form order.
Will it overwrite our rates?	No. Saved estimates keep their original values unless you explicitly recalculate. Calibration suggestions from past jobs need your Approve, Edit, or Dismiss.
Do we have to change how we email suppliers?	No. Send from the platform, or download the files and send from your own inbox to anyone, including people outside your directory. Quotes import the same either way.
Is our data kept separate?	Yes. Each company's records, uploaded files, and quote links are walled off from every other company. That separation is enforced in the database and in file storage, not just on screen, and automated tests attempt cross-company access to records, files, and quote links to confirm it fails.

What TrueGrade will deliberately not do

- Ship with generic production rates, "industry average" costs, or a price database.
- Automatically import, adjust, or apply anything without your review. Nothing flows into an estimate silently.
- Send an RFQ you have not previewed and approved.
- Calculate earthwork from PDF contours, or treat AI measurement as final. It is always flagged for review.
- Force you to finish a step inside the platform. Every file is downloadable.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Review quantities			
ITEM	QTY	SOURCE	CONFIDENCE
8" sewer main	1,240 LF	Bid schedule, item 204	● High CONFIRMED
Storm inlets	18 EA	Structure table, C-7	● High CONFIRMED
12" storm pipe	860 LF	AI SUGGESTION C-5	● Low REVIEW
Paved area, Type B	2,410 SY	AI SUGGESTION C-9	● Low REVIEW

Every quantity is a draft until you confirm it. Concept illustration with sample values; final design will differ.

How was this calculated?	
Quantity	from bid schedule, sheet C-4 Confirmed
Crew days	= qty ÷ your production rate Your value
Labor	= crew days × your crew cost Your value
Pipe	= qty × waste % × price Quote, dated
Bedding	= qty × your CY per LF Unverified

Every line shows its math and how much you can rely on each input. Concept illustration.

The inputs that make it yours.

TrueGrade starts empty, so it is exactly as good as the information behind it. The good news: you already have most of it. **Send it in whatever form it exists today** (spreadsheets, PDFs, scans, even photos of printed reports). Import tools read it and your team reviews the result. You don't need everything up front: each item is tied to the phase where we first need it, and your files stay in your private workspace.

The people we need

Executive sponsor

Sets company defaults (markup, overhead, tax, bonding), clears roadblocks, and signs off at each milestone.

Lead estimator (our champion)

Our day-to-day partner. Knows how bids really get built, tests every phase with real work.

Admin

Owns rates, approvals, the supplier directory, and email settings after launch.

Purchasing contact

Confirms supplier categories and contacts, and helps us test real supplier quotes.

IT / web contact

Only if you want to send from your company domain: adds a few DNS records we supply.

TIER 1 To get started

Needed at kickoff · Phase 1

WHAT WE NEED	WHY	FORMAT THAT WORKS	BEST OWNER	PHASE
Logo, defaults, and standard RFQ email	Your branding leads on PDFs and RFQs. Defaults: markup %, overhead %, sales tax, project types bid (Gov / State / Commercial), bonding and insurance approach. Plus your usual RFQ subject, message, and signature.	Logo file, hex color if known, and a short conversation	Executive sponsor / Admin	1
Supplier and subcontractor directories	Power RFQ suggestions by category and service area: company, contacts, emails, phones, categories supplied, preferred flag. Subs cover striping, fencing, electrical, traffic control, and so on.	Any list: Excel, CSV, exported contacts	Purchasing	1
Materials and current prices	The start of your material library: name, unit, unit cost, supplier, date last quoted, density (tons/CY), waste %, spec notes.	Your current price sheet or spreadsheet	Estimator / Purchasing	1
Labor roles and rates	Operator, laborer, foreman, flagger, pipe layer, and others: base wage, burden %, and prevailing / Davis-Bacon rate. Current wage determinations are welcome.	Spreadsheet, payroll report, or wage determination PDF	Payroll / Admin	1
Equipment costs	Each machine's hourly ownership and operating cost, standby rate, and mobilization cost per move.	Your equipment cost report as it is	Equipment manager	1
Baseline numbers	Bids per year, typical estimator hours per bid, typical bid package size, and current win rate, so we can prove the improvement.	Your best estimate	Executive sponsor	1

TIER 2 To make estimates accurate

Phases 2–4

WHAT WE NEED	WHY	FORMAT THAT WORKS	BEST OWNER	PHASE
Crew production rates	Real-world output for your main activities and which equipment and labor make up each crew. We ask in plain language, so you never need the formula.	A working session, plus notes from recent jobs	Lead estimator / Superintendent	2
Soil types and behavior	The soils you regularly encounter, with your own swell and shrink percentages.	A short list; we can walk through it together	Lead estimator	2
Your most-used assemblies	A starting set (we suggest 10–20) of the work packages you price most often, such as pipe by size and depth, structures, aggregate base, paving, and curb and gutter.	A working session, plus any existing unit-price sheets	Lead estimator	2
Recent bid packages	To test and tune extraction on the documents you really receive. Please include the mix of owners you bid (federal, state DOT, county/city, private): plan set, bid schedule, specifications, geotech, addenda.	PDF and Excel, as issued	Lead estimator	3
Your finished takeoff and estimate for those jobs	So we can compare TrueGrade's draft against your known-good answer. This is the most valuable test we can run.	Whatever you produced (Excel, PDF, notes)	Lead estimator	3–4

TIER 3 To make it smarter over time

Phases 5–9

WHAT WE NEED	WHY	FORMAT THAT WORKS	BEST OWNER	PHASE
Recent real supplier quotes	To test quote import on the formats your suppliers actually send.	As received: PDF, spreadsheet, or email	Estimator / Purchasing	5
Email sending choice	Send from TrueGrade (works immediately), from your own company domain (needs IT), or from each estimator's own mailbox.	A decision. We explain the pros and cons.	Admin / IT	6
Earthwork and CAD samples	To validate cut/fill from LandXML existing and proposed surfaces, if you use them.	LandXML, DXF/DWG, or CSV point files	Lead estimator	7
State DOT and other standard specs	Bid items often reference standard specifications that are not in the bid package. Having them lets RFQs state exact requirements.	PDF	Lead estimator	7
Past job cost reports	The fuel for calibration: bid estimate plus final job cost for completed jobs. Start with a handful of recent, well-documented jobs.	PDF, Excel/CSV, or images of printed reports	Operations / Accounting	8
Your bid form and bid summary format	So the client-version summary and bid form export look the way you expect.	A sample of what you send today	Lead estimator	9

Quick decisions we will walk through with you

- ✓ Days before a material price counts as stale
- ✓ Which project and owner types you bid
- ✓ % gap between your takeoff and the owner's schedule that triggers a review
- ✓ Your AI processing limits
- ✓ How far ahead of quote deadlines reminders go out
- ✓ Who is an Admin and who is an Estimator

Built and proven in stages.

We build in nine phases, grouped into six milestones. **Each phase is confirmed working with your team before the next begins**, so you see real progress and can redirect early. Timing for each milestone is agreed at kickoff.



MILESTONE	WHAT SHIPS	WHAT YOUR TEAM CAN DO	WHAT WE NEED FROM YOU
1 • Foundation & Company Setup Phases 1–2	Your private workspace, secure sign-in, Admin and Estimator roles, and the full setup wizard (labor, equipment, materials, suppliers, production rates, soils, assemblies).	Load your company's costs, supplier directory, and assemblies into one place and see a live cost per unit.	All Tier 1 items, plus production rates, soil factors, and a starter set of assemblies.
2 • Plan Room & Takeoff Phase 3	Bid package upload, sheet index, plan viewer, bid schedule and plan-table extraction with mandatory review, and manual takeoff tools.	Upload a real bid package and get a reviewed, source-linked quantity takeoff.	Recent bid packages, plus your finished takeoff for comparison.
3 • Estimate Builder Phase 4	Estimate populated from confirmed quantities, bid item mapping, job overrides, formula transparency, and confidence indicators.	Build a complete, explainable estimate from your own data and compare it to your known-good number.	Your finished estimates for the sample jobs; feedback on assembly mapping.
4 • Get Prices Phases 5–6	Material list, numbered RFQs, export-and-send-yourself, quote import, and comparison. Then send-from-TrueGrade: three email methods, supplier quote form, status tracking, reminders.	Get prices out and back in, whichever way you prefer to send, and drop selected quotes into the estimate.	Real supplier quotes; your email-sending decision; an IT contact if using your domain.
5 • Advanced Automation Phase 7	AI-assisted measurement from drawings (always flagged), LandXML earthwork import, addenda diffing with RFQ revisions, and specification extraction.	Speed up takeoff, handle addenda cleanly, and compute cut/fill from real surfaces.	LandXML / CAD samples, standard specs, and an addendum example.
6 • Learn & Deliver Phases 8–9	Historical job import and variance calibration, job close-out, bid summary PDFs (client and internal), bid form export, and full Excel export.	Calibrate estimates against your real results and produce the final bid documents.	Past job cost reports; your bid form and summary format.

Milestone reviews

At the end of each milestone we run real work through what was built with your lead estimator. We move on only when it meets your standard.

A rollout with zero risk to your next bid.

Estimators adopt tools that prove themselves on real work without putting a live bid at risk. So we propose a rollout where you never bet a bid on TrueGrade until it has earned it.

STEP 1 Kick off Name the sponsor and lead estimator, agree on success measures, capture baselines, collect Tier 1 inputs.	STEP 2 Guided setup Walk through setup with your lead estimator, import what you already have, and watch the completeness score climb.	STEP 3 Shadow bid Run a recent or live bid through TrueGrade beside your usual process. Compare quantities, costs, and time. Close gaps together.	STEP 4 Calibrate Import past jobs, review the variance findings, and approve the adjustments that match your experience.	STEP 5 Go live Bid a live job on TrueGrade, keeping your current process as backup until your team is confident.
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How we will know it is working

At kickoff we agree on a few plain measures against your baselines. Examples:

- ✓ Draft quantities agree with your own finished takeoff within a tolerance you set.
- ✓ Estimator time per bid, compared with your baseline.
- ✓ The share of each estimate backed by verified, calibrated, or quoted data (which TrueGrade reports on every estimate).

Your getting-started checklist

Send these when you can. Anything in any format is fine, and partial is fine too.

- ☐ **Name your executive sponsor and lead estimator** · Our two main points of contact on your side.
- ☐ **Logo and brand color** · For white-labelled PDFs and RFQ spreadsheets.
- ☐ **Supplier and subcontractor lists** · Any format: Excel, CSV, exported contacts.
- ☐ **Your current materials price sheet** · With supplier and date last quoted where you have them.
- ☐ **3–5 recent bid packages, and your finished takeoff or estimate for at least one** · Across the owner types you bid: federal, state DOT, county/city, private.
- ☐ **Company defaults** · Markup, overhead, sales tax, and how you handle bonding and insurance costs.
- ☐ **Baseline numbers** · Bids per year, hours per bid, and win rate, so we can measure the difference.

Ready when you are.

Tell us what we missed, name your two people, and send what you have. We will handle the rest, step by step.

The Answer AI
theanswerai.com